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Ideology, Fiction, Narrative

TERRY EAGLETON

In ideology men do indeed express, not the relation between them and their conditions of existence, but *the way* they live the relation between them and their conditions of existence: this presupposes both a real relation and an "imaginary," "lived" relation. Ideology, then, is the expression of the relation between men and their "world," that is, the (overdetermined) unity of the real relation and the imaginary relation between them and their real conditions of existence. In ideology the real relation is inevitably invested in the imaginary relation, a relation that *expresses a will* (conservative, conformist, reformist or revolutionary), a hope or a nostalgia, rather than describing a reality.

Louis Althusser, *For Marx*

I begin with this celebrated quotation from Althusser, not because I believe that his general theory of the ideological is in the least adequate,¹ but because it marks for me an emphatic, irreversible shift in Marxist thinking on the matter—a shift that may truly be described as "epochal." The case which Althusser is concerned to subvert may be sketched as follows. There is, in the ideological, a confrontation between "subject" and "object"; and from this confrontation, either because of an inherent cunning or duplicity in the object itself (which is not what it seems to be), or because of the interference of certain distorting elements ("class-interests," perhaps) with the cognitive apparatus of the speculative subject, a phenomenon known as "false consciousness" is generated. Ideology is a deformed representation of the object—a "screen" or "filter" which we can nonetheless peer behind to obtain a glimpse of the object as it really is. Insofar as any such theory of ideology must, for Althusser, rest upon an irredeemably empiricist epistemology, it can do no more than produce an ideological version of the ideological.

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¹Perhaps it is as well to sketch out in schematic form what I regard as the major defects of Althusser's theory of ideology, as exemplified in the renowned essay on "Ideological State Apparatuses" in *Lenin and Philosophy*. Althusser's theory in this essay is (a) *functionalist*: it presumes an "intention" on the part of the social formation to

If this is the case, then we need to look sceptically at Marx's own embryonic theory of the ideological in *Capital* and elsewhere. For it certainly seems as though Marx believes that the capitalist social formation just does spontaneously present itself to knowledge in mystifying forms—that the very mechanisms by which it generates its phenomena are also the mechanisms by which it breeds illusion. There is an essence named “abstract labor” which both crystallizes and conceals itself in the phenomena of commodities; there is a real process of exploitation which cannot help but belie itself in the apparently equitable exchange of the wage-contract. If this were really so, then one wonders why ideological *practices* and *apparatuses* are necessary at all. As “reinforcement,” perhaps; but it would seem on the whole that the capitalist social formation, as far as its ideological self-reproduction goes, is on this account well able to look after itself, without the necessity of a specific ideological “region.” What the account represses is precisely the process of ideological *labor*—that process of signifying practice whereby, within determinate protocols, certain specific ideological “objects” are actually constituted. For nothing, as we know, is simply “given” to knowledge; and when Marx comments in a famous sentence that there would be no need for science if phenomena coincided with their essences, it can only be because he (of all people!) has momentarily forgotten that science is a *practice*.

Ideology, then, is not to be reduced to miscognition, but is to be seen as signifying a set of practical relations with the “real.” That such relations may well involve miscognition is then the next urgent point to make. If I eat aspirin under the illusion that they are candy with the coloring sucked off, then I can certainly be said to be miscognizing the real. But if I *persistently* engage in this practice, then it may at least occur to an observer that my miscognitions are not the *cause* of my behavior, but a necessary support of it. My miscognitions are an element or support of that “lived” relation to the real which we might, perhaps, term “psychotic.”² The paranoiac who believes that the television set is watching him cannot be cured by a re-attunement of his cognitive apparatus: his miscognitions are essential elements or effects of a way of “living” his “world.”

The logical point at stake here is that propositions may be true or false, but practices cannot be. I cannot be *mistaken* about the way I “live” my relation to the real. I may, of course, *misreport* it to another, but I cannot get it wrong. Even if my “lived” relation to the real is of the kind which used to be described within another rubric as “bad faith,” it remains the case that this *is* my “lived” relation to the real, and no mistake. This is not to claim, on the other hand, that human subjects do not constantly enunciate false propositions about their conditions of existence. It is rather to claim that such false propositions do not constitute what is specific about the ideological, and this in a dual sense. First, because false propositions are by no means necessarily ideological, just as ideological propositions are by no means necessarily false. But secondly, and more crucially, because it is only in a loose sense

reproduce itself, which voids the place of effectivity of the class struggle; (b) *economistic and technicist*: ideology exists to help reproduce the mode of production, itself reduced to the functions of economic agents within the social division of labor; (c) *structuralist*: the social division of labor is a structure of locations to which specific forms of subjectivity are automatically assigned; one has the form of subjectivity appropriate to one's place within the structure; (d) *empiricist*: it presupposes a pre-given subject, already inexplicably equipped with certain “universal” attributes of consciousness, who will then be “hailed” by the structure, rather than a subject contradictorily constructed in specific discursive and non-discursive practices; (e) *idealist*: all economic agents are seen as individual human subjects, and social relations consequently reduced to intersubjective ones. These errors apart, the theory is really quite a suggestive starting-point. The most useful critique of Althusser's theory of ideology I know is in Cutler, Hindess, Hirst, and Hussain, *Marx's “Capital” and Capitalism Today* (London, 1977), vol. 1.

² I do not of course intend to imply any general analogy between the ideological and the pathological.

that we can speak of "ideological propositions" at all.

My claim is that "ideological propositions" are only *apparently* propositions about the real. They are, if I may detach a phrase of I.A. Richards from the flagrantly ideological context in which it is embedded, "pseudo-statements," para- or "virtual" statements. If we take them as referential, as descriptions of states of affairs, then this is only because we have been tricked by what the linguists might call their "surface grammar" into an ideological miscognition of their real character. What differentiates ideological "propositions" from genuinely referential enunciations is that the former may be "decoded" into "emotive" (subject-oriented) discourse. An ideological "proposition" such as "The Irish are inferior to the English," which appears to describe an object, can in fact be decoded into some such statement as: "I don't like the Irish." That, of course, is too simple a formulation: it is not, for example, necessary that the *speaker* personally dislike the Irish. A fuller explication of the statement would be something like: "Given these determinate historical conditions, it is necessary that we English should on the whole dislike the Irish." (Although it is a fact about the nature of the ideological that, if a speaker were able to enunciate this latter statement, it is improbable that he could seriously enunciate the former.) It is not, of course, the case that all emotive discourse is ideological, or that all ideological discourse is para-propositional; but it is essential to claim that, even where we are confronted with the most highly elaborated theoretical ideology (Thomism, Comtism), it is possible to discover the transformational rules which will allow us to decode it into a basic set of emotive enunciations.³

This is not to say that *every* "proposition" in an ideological discourse has its emotive equivalent, any more than every piece of a dream-text may be unravelled to its attendant "referent." There will be statements in the discourse which genuinely are referential, and which may be either verified or falsified. Nor is it to claim that the business of verification or falsification is politically unimportant: if one really can show the speaker that "The Irish are inferior to the English" is either empirically untrue or logically incoherent, well and good; it might just have an effect. What *is* important to recognize is that the cognitive structure of an ideological discourse is subordinated to its emotive structure—that such cognitions or miscognitions as it contains are on the whole articulated according to the demands, the field of discursive play, of the emotive "intentionality" it embodies. I say "on the whole," because to say otherwise would be to mistake the homogenizing character of ideological discourse for an achieved homogeneity—to ignore, in short, its contradictions, the points at which (let us say) a contradiction between the cognitive and emotive may provide a fissure for the levers of deconstruction. One way in which ideological discourses forestall such deconstruction is by articulating themselves in such a way as to repress the mechanisms of their generation. Those mechanisms, if I may be allowed to flirt with Althusser's otherwise questionable notion of "structural causality," are included within them as an absence or internal limit; the ideology will be internally inflected in such a way as to confer a partial invisibility on its productive matrix. In this sense, there is a limited analogy between the ideological and the pathological: both kinds of discourse must be read symptomatically for that repression of their formative processes of which they are the product.

To view the ideological in this light may help to console those who broadly endorse the thesis that it is a matter of "lived relations" rather than "false consciousness," but who find themselves embarrassed by one of that thesis's inevitable consequences—namely, that

³ It should perhaps be added that the relations between "theoretical" and "behavioral" ideologies (I take the latter term from Volosinov) are, of course, dialectical: what is theoretically elaborated returns to influence what is "lived."

ideology will survive as long as subjects do. For such a claim does not necessarily entail that *miscognition* will be a structural feature of post-revolutionary social formations, as long as miscognitions are seen as possible "supports" or "effects" of the ideological rather than as definitive of it. It is not the case that post-revolutionary subjects will spontaneously "know" the social formation in the very grain and texture of their "lived relations" to it, in some felicitous conflation of Idea and Existence. But neither is it the case that the masses will continue to grope and fumble in ideological miasma while the party, perched above them, conducts its untainted dialogue with Truth. Only the most paranoid humanistic reading of Althusser could detect such an implication. Ideology is not the metaphysical other of Knowledge, and therefore need not involve miscognition; that it does so in class society says something of the conditions necessary in such societies for securing the relative coherence of the subject.

Ideological language, then, is the language of wishing, cursing, fearing, denigrating, celebrating, and so on. And if this is so, then perhaps the closest analogue we have to ideology is nothing less than literary fiction. If what is in question is a form of language which, while often apparently referential, in fact reveals itself to theoretical inquiry as a complex encodement of certain "lived" relations to the real which may be neither verified nor falsified, what more exemplary model is there to hand than that of literary discourse itself? Like ideology, literary texts frequently involve cognitive propositions, but those propositions are not present to inform us about the real. When a novel tells what the capital city of France is, it is not enforcing a geographical truth; it is either obliquely signaling a fact about its character as discourse ("this is realism") which induces us to "live" more completely that discourse's emotive intentionality, or it is marshaling a local "support" for a particular emotive enunciation. If that local unit of discourse is falsifiable, the enunciation as a whole is not. In realist literature, the emotive level is slid under the pseudo-referential, and to this degree such literature resembles nothing quite so much as theoretical ideology.

There is another, perhaps rather more obvious sense in which ideology and literary fiction are analogous in form. Let us consider for a moment the question of what constitutes the definition of a piece of discourse as "literary." There is a notice in the London Underground system which reads: "Dogs must be carried on the escalator." This, I suppose, is a self-evidently "non-literary," unambiguous bit of discourse (although it is not, perhaps, wholly unambiguous: does it mean that you *must* carry a dog on the escalator?). What would count as reading this notice in a "literary" manner? One answer might be to read it with due attention to the specific density of its significations—to allow oneself to be arrested by the abrupt, minatory staccato of those initial monosyllables; to let one's mind drift, by the time it has arrived at "carried," to certain suggestive resonances of helping lame dogs through life; to find enacted in the very lilt and inflection of "escalator" the rolling up-and-down movement of its referent. Anyone with sufficient useless ingenuity can play this game indefinitely. But it presupposes that the "literary" is in effect the "poetic"—that discourse is produced or constructed as "literary" by a palpable foregrounding of its signifying practice. It does not help us to understand why the final sentence of Hemingway's *A Farewell To Arms* is "literary"—the answer to that, of course, being that it is "literary" because it is the final sentence to Hemingway's *A Farewell To Arms*. The paradigm case of reading the notice in question in a "literary" manner would surely be that of the late-night drunk who, doubled over the escalator handrail with the notice two inches from his eyeballs, muttered: "How true." A "literary" reading, that is to say, is one which applies certain generalizing conventions to the discourse at issue, prying it loose from its

immediate referential context. Where signifiatory foregrounding occurs, it occurs as a "support" of this practice rather than as an alternative to it. And if this is the case, then one can understand why the "literary" has the ideological potency it does. For we know, do we not, that the opposite of the particular is the universal; if it is irrelevant to a "literary" reading whether Robert Burns actually had a lover who for some bizarre reason seemed to him to resemble a red rose, it must be because all women are a little like that.

Let me revert, however, to my previous point of analogy between literary and ideological language. To claim that both kinds of language are fundamentally nonreferential is equivalent to claiming, in J.L. Austin's terms, that both are "performative" rather than "constative." They have the form of sentences like "I bet you five pounds," or "I hope you fall off your bicycle," rather than the form of sentences like "You just fell off your bicycle." Moreover, they belong to the "illocutionary" rather than "perlocutionary" class of constative statements, insofar as the effect they are constituted to bring about is potential ("I warn you not to throw me out of the window") rather than secured in the saying ("I take you as my lawful wedded wife"). If all of this is familiar enough to any reader of *New Literary History*, it may be worth pointing up its relevance to a materialist theory of literary texts. What the "speech act" theory of texts crucially emphasizes is that texts are *practices*. Literary texts do things to us. What they bring about is not something that happens after we have finished reading them, like joining a picket line or being kinder to one's children, but is effected (if at all) by and in the reading. Since all literary texts are in some sense ideological—that is to say, aligned somewhere on a spectrum of significations which contribute either to securing or transforming the conditions of existence of the dominant social relations of production—it follows that to read is to become engaged in the class struggle. It is quite as real a way of being engaged in the class struggle as disrupting a fascist meeting, even though it is by no means as important, and, from the viewpoint of revolutionary politics, could well be dispensed with altogether.

If it seems implausible that a materialist theory of the text can be generated from the work of an Oxford linguistic philosopher undistinguished for his revolutionary sentiments, it is worth noting the incongruous parallelism between the work of Austin and V.N. Vološinov's *Marxism and the Philosophy of Language*. When Austin tells us that "the total speech act in the total situation is the only actual phenomenon which, in the last resort, we are engaged in elucidating,"⁴ he might well be quoting from Vološinov's magnificent study. For Vološinov, the literary text must be grasped wholly in terms of its contextual intentionality—as articulated discourse or *parole* rendered merely unintelligible once it is deprived of its thrust of concrete effectivity and collapsed back into the anonymous inertia of *langue*. One index of such effectivity is *tonality*, in the face of which pre-Kristevan semiotics is powerless. Textual tone may, of course, constitute a significant semantic element; but since it is not a matter of B flat or C sharp, it can yield itself only to a hermeneutical, rather than putatively scientific, reading.

There are other suggestive models for the notion of the literary text as practice rather than object. We might do worse, for example, than to re-examine Brecht's pedagogical concept of the *Gest* or *Gestus*, conceived as that sustained curve of intentionality, that skeletal stance or "set" towards an object mimed in word and body, to which the complexities of a piece of stage action and discourse can be illuminatingly reduced. It is even possible that we might still salvage something from Kenneth Burke's idiosyncratic

⁴ *How To Do Things With Words* (Oxford, 1975), p. 148.

vision of the text as “symbolic strategy” oriented to the “encompassing” of concrete situations; or discover a parallel to Vološinov’s insistence on contextual reconstruction in Hans-Georg Gadamer’s hermeneutical project of reconstituting the “question” to which the literary text is an “answer.” If the eclecticism of these sources is a cause for theoretical anxiety, it may perhaps also suggest how scattered and marooned such attempts to think through the text as practice have been—may indicate, in short, the massive *repression* of that concept, in a corpus of traditional criticism which can only view such enterprises as agitational or utilitarian.

There is, however, a problem in shifting so rapidly from a discussion of the “emotive” character of literary and ideological discourse to an emphasis on the text as practice. For it involves sliding from one end of Jakobson’s communicational schema to the other—shifting with unseemly haste from the speaker-oriented location to what Jakobson terms the “conative,” or recipient-directed. To assert that literary texts are essentially practices is to argue that they are all, without exception, *rhetorical*. But how is such a claim then to be squared with the emotive set I have outlined above? This is not a problem which need arise for those who hold to a humanistic concept of textual practice. For them, “practice” is simply a rather more modish way of talking about what the Romantic tradition has all along called “expression”; and if you can occasionally modulate it to “praxis” then all the better.⁵ The humanistic conception of the text as practice is stoutly subject-oriented, and as such enters into no conflict with the “emotive.” But to speak of textual practice as rhetoric is to examine its possible objective effects rather than its motivating impulses, just as to speak of the “contextual intentionality” of the work is to ask how its structuration inevitably defines a certain field of possible effectivity, rather than to inquire into certain ghostly aims in its author’s head. What we have to say, then, is that the literary text, by conferring a specific *form* upon “emotive” materials, transmutes them to the “rhetorical.” It is analogous, therefore, to the operations of propagandist forms of ideology, which do precisely the same, or indeed in some sense to the work of theoretical ideologies, which can figure for us as complex, rhetorically effective transmutations of emotive ideological discourse. (I need hardly add that I am not “equating” literature with ideological propaganda, crucially true though it is that all literature is propagandist.)

There is a further problem involved in speaking of literary texts as practices. This is that we may be led too quickly to assimilate the curious kind of practice which such texts constitute to the more tangible, “living” practice of the speech act itself. If such a tendency is present in the work of Vološinov, it is also apparent in Medvedev—not surprisingly if the two writers are identical. In the Russian Formalist model, Medvedev complains, “the receiver does not ‘feel’ the other human being, other men, friends or enemies, behind the work; he ‘feels’ only the object, or more exactly his own empty sensation, produced in him by this object.”⁶ The “speech act” theory of literary texts is always in danger of a humanism which reduces the materiality of the work to such spontaneous intersubjective transparency, to that coercive “presence” of the living voice which, in the days before Derrida, we were able to conceive of as pre- or anti-textual. What we need then to remind ourselves of is the fact that, if the text is only “virtually” locutionary, there is a sense in which it is only “virtually” illocutionary as well. The text is not actually a speech act: it is more of a parody of one. It has, we may say, an “enunciation effect,” offers itself as a “metaphor” of *parole*. And if

⁵ See, for example, Alan Swingewood, *The Novel and Revolution* (London, 1976).

⁶ Quoted in H. Günther (ed.), *Marxismo e formalismo: Documenti di una controversia teorico letteraria* (Naples, 1974), p. 141.

the text is a parody of a speech act, we might risk saying that the "modernist" text is a parody of that parody. When Samuel Beckett concluded *Molloy* by telling us: "It is midnight. The rain is beating on the windows. It was not midnight. It was not raining," he brazenly reveals the virtuality of the textual "enunciation," exposes the work as a machine for producing pseudo-statements. It is in such doubling of the text, such raising of the parody to the second power, that literary language discovers one escape-hatch from the prison-house of ideology. For if English chauvinists were able to say: "The Irish are inferior to the English. The Irish are not inferior to the English," they would not merely have adopted another position: they would have discovered something about the operations of the ideological mechanism itself, its production of a closure constantly threatened by the heterogeneity of language.

It is, regrettably, evasive to speak of the ideological without at least raising the vexed issue of its supposed opposite, the "scientific." Yet it is difficult to know quite how to do this best—where to situate oneself on a terrain at present carved up between a scientific rationalism which, in uniquely privileging a particular discourse, conflates the order of the real; a humanism for which scientificity is itself the last word in reification; and a deconstructionism which tells us that we can talk only of our talk. It will not furnish a fourth position, although it may perhaps interrogate the other three a little, to ask what exactly Marx did to Ricardo. To claim that Marx's discourse is "scientific," whereas Ricardo's is "ideological," is to argue that Marx is capable of providing a "symptomatic reading" of Ricardo's texts. It is not to assert that Marx's text yields us the whole truth, and Ricardo's no truth at all; it is to claim rather that Marx, in examining the repressions, contradictions and lacunae in Ricardo's writings, is able to construct the concepts which allow him not only to explain what Ricardo cannot explain, but to explain why he cannot explain it.

It is not because Marx's discourse is "disinterested" that it is able to do this. All Marxist theory is located within the framework of socialist ideology: it is because Marx has already taken up a "proletarian class-position" in the realm of theory that he is so concerned to deconstruct Ricardo's texts. Marxist language, like Ricardo's, is "closed" by a wish, a hope, an intention, a denial; it is just that this particular discursive closure is able to construct the data of the capitalist mode of production in such a way as to explain them more adequately than can the "closure" of bourgeois political economy. "More adequately" cannot be translated to mean "in a way which furthers proletarian revolution," which would be to relapse into an historicist view of Marxist theory; it refers, rather, to that which gives us knowledge. To say that F.R. Leavis's reading of D.H. Lawrence is more adequate than T.S. Eliot's is not to claim that the latter is ideological and the former is not; it is to argue that Leavis's problematic constructs the text in such a way as to yield superior explanatory power. It is not, of course, that Leavis's reading "represents the truth of the object," in a pleasing adequation of discourse and the "real," for by what transcendental, arbitrarily privileged body of metaconcepts could such an adequation be measured? There are no objects which are not constructed in discourse; it is just that certain constructions yield more consistent and comprehensive explanations than others.

The need for knowledge, if I may espouse a disreputable anthropologism, is rooted in the material structure of the human animal. We need knowledge because we need to have power. And Habermas is certainly right that, in this sense, all "science" is interested to its roots. Social formations tend to privilege certain modes of knowledge as what one might call "paradigm cases" of the knowledge activity—modes which, over a period of time, have

proved to produce demonstrably reliable results. It is these modes of knowledge which thus tend from time to time to receive the honorific title of "science." For the nineteenth century, that paradigm case was the natural sciences. When Marxism, in a crucially significant rhetorical gesture, claimed to be a "science," it was situating itself within the terrain of that which had proved to be on the whole reliably knowledgeable. It was also, of course, claiming more than that. It was pointing out, quite correctly, that there are certain indispensable minimum conditions for knowledge, which the natural sciences had theoretically encoded—rigor, consistency, the attempted "self-decentering" of the scientific worker and so on. But these methodological requirements are of course necessary rather than sufficient conditions for knowledge; there is no more rigorous, scrupulously systematic method of inquiry than magic. "Scientificity," then, cannot be a quality of method, if by "science" one means that which has on the whole been reliably demonstrated to produce (at least some of the time) theoretical knowledge. If this were so, Northrop Frye would certainly have to be granted more serious attention than one feels disposed to lavish upon him. The danger of forgetting that the natural sciences are for us a "paradigm case" of knowledge is that we shall be led to try to develop some "general theory of science." It would be rather like someone trying to deduce the rules of all other games from a close study of football. This is not what we have in mind when we characterize football as a "paradigm case" of games; we are saying, rather, to an ignorant observer: "This is the *kind of thing* games are."

Michel Foucault reminds us that all discourses are "closed," in the sense of being bounded, articulated practical domains. "Closure," then, cannot be what is *specific* to the ideological. The signifying practice of nuclear physics certainly fixes and privileges representations drawn from the potentially infinite heterogeneity of discourse as surely as does Nazism.⁷ It would betray a purely formalistic notion of the ideological to insist that plurality, polyvalence, multiaccentuality *in themselves* subvert the imaginary paralysis of the ideological signifier. Whether they do so or not hinges upon the concrete conjuncture in which such discourse is practiced and constructed. And we know too well the anarchistic conclusions to which such a theory tends to lead: a petty-bourgeois formalism redoubles itself in a petty-bourgeois politics. We need, in fact, to treat with a certain sympathetic caution that view of the ideological which harks upon the political imperative of putting the subject into process and self-contradiction. For one thing, it is not at all clear quite what status is to be assigned to the notorious theoretical absence over which all sophisticated materialists now ritually beat their breasts—the missing "theory of the subject." It is not that we can in the least afford to dispense with constructing such a theory; it is just that, if the Marxism of 1979 is mutilated by such an absence, so was the Marxism of 1917, and yet one or two notable events occurred in that year. And those who riposte: "Ah yes, and look what happened!" hold a curious theory of the rise of Stalinism. More to the point than that, perhaps, is the striking irony by which some of those who now insist upon the centrality of the "subject-in-process" are led, by a peculiarly sanguine reading of Maoist "cultural revolution," to locate such a phenomenon at the very heart of a variant of Stalinism itself. It is odd, to say the least, that a theory of contradiction and heterogeneity is mobilized in support of a global counterrevolutionary politics whose effect is, precisely, the repression

⁷ Perhaps the most striking example of "discursive closure" is nothing less than Saussurean linguistics. Saussure's model of *langue*, which fixes discursive units in stable interrelation by repressing the heterogeneous nature of *parole*, may serve in this sense as a kind of paradigm of the ideological.

and negotiation of social contradictions. And yet the oddness is perhaps only apparent: for is there not an internal bond between the petty-bourgeois idealism of formalist semiotics, and that other blend of petty-bourgeois idealism and counterrevolutionary containment which distinguishes Maoism?

To regard ideology as “discursive closure” is, among other things, a way of rescuing it from any merely economistic definition, of the kind embraced by Althusser in his essay on Ideological State Apparatuses. Ideology is now to be seen not positively, as a material force for the reproduction of subjects distributed within the labor process, but negatively, as that which by forestalling the release of contradictions within the subject helps to secure the conditions of existence of the dominant social relations of production. Such a thesis, attractively enough, grants the ideological its securing effects but simultaneously permits it its own specific conditions of effectivity, refusing to reduce it to a support of a functionalist theory of the social formation. But it remains to be shown what precisely are the *relations* between the subjective contradictions of the capitalist social formation which Marxism has traditionally discerned. Julia Kristeva describes the linguistic “revolution” of Lautréamont and Mallarmé as “a practice that one could compare to that of political revolution: the one achieves for the subject what the other introduces into society.”⁸ “Compare”: one had taken it that homologues were precisely what we were trying to escape. Of course it is tendentious to extract a single sentence from a lengthy work, but it is questionable whether Kristeva’s method in *La révolution du langage poétique* can indeed lead us beyond the profoundly suggestive positing of parallels. And the obverse of homologizing, as we know too well from the work of Lucien Goldmann, is conflation: it is thus that Kristeva, here and elsewhere, is able to construct a psychoanalytic typology of social formations which seems to assume precisely those settled relations between Marxism and psychoanalysis which are currently most fraught and obscure.

For all its undoubted insights, the semiotic and psychoanalytic theory of the subject has an ideological appeal within contemporary Marxism which it is not difficult to account for. It shares with commonplace bourgeois idealism an excessively subject-oriented problematic; but it promises simultaneously to produce a theory of the subject which is non-humanist, non-individualist, non-voluntarist—in a word, materialist. The subject is displaced from its privileged position as unitary, transcendental, self-generative origin and grasped instead as the incoherent effect of a transindividual process of material signification inscribed within certain definite, historically particular practices and apparatuses. That this constitutes a major theoretical development in the conceptualization of the subject seems to me incontrovertible. Yet for all that it does not break definitively with its ideological past. Insofar as the whole of the ideological, à la Althusser, remains firmly predicated upon the subject, the theory retains a strong, residual idealism. If it is true that certain ideological discourses (“literature,” for example) are most directly active in the construction of the subject, this does not seem the case with other such modes of discourse—the juridical formulations governing the transactions of joint-stock companies, for example. If the theory repulses all traces of humanism and voluntarism, it nevertheless remains serenely undisturbed by such phenomena in the kinds of political practice it espouses. And if it constitutes a “materialism,” then it occasionally seems that it does so only by virtue of its ritual incantation of the term “material.” In the face of such incantation, it needs to be firmly, simple-mindedly asserted that if the *signifier* is indubitably material, *signification* is not.

⁸ *La révolution du langage poétique* (Paris, 1974), p. 14.

There is no possible sense in which meanings and values can be said to be "material," other than in the most sloppily metaphorical use of the term. That meanings and values are inscribed in the material practices, discourses, and institutions of which they are the products—there is nothing in this important and illuminating assertion which entails the "materiality" (as opposed to the "materialization") of sense. If meanings *are* material, then the term "materialism" naturally ceases to be intelligible. Since there is nothing which the concept excludes, it ceases to have value. Nor does this argument presuppose a merely vulgar materialism—a trite insistence that meanings do not have corners and velocity as lorries do. It is meant to enforce the point that it is occasionally useful and important to distinguish between such occurrences as thinking and bleeding; it is not intended as a wily way of smuggling back in a "base/superstructure" model which it is precisely the point of an emphasis on the materiality of the signifier to subvert.

The most blatant ideological disability of the theory in question, however, is its intransigent individualism. The unconscious, as we know, is transindividual; Jung's "discovery" of the "collective unconscious," as Freud's sardonic comment on it suggests, was that of a man who mistook a tautology for a truth. But it remains the case that the subject of semiotic/psychoanalytic theory is essentially the *nuclear* subject. A salutary dismissal of the idealist notion of a "class-subject" topples over into a refusal to theorize the concept of *class-solidarity*. There is no point at which the estrangement of such theories from the practice of revolutionary politics is more glaringly evident. The collapsing of such a politics into the abstract circuits of "desire" (Deleuze, Guattari, Lyotard) signifies a wholesale rejection of the Leninist tradition (and its Trotskyist continuation). It is, at least, clear that we can no longer continue to theorize the concept of class-solidarity and class-practice in the terms of some essentialist class-subject—clear, in short, that an insurrectionary class is not to be grasped as some imaginary, self-recuperated coherence, but as a decentered practice caught up in a process of division and contradiction. What is urgent is that we find ways of thinking through that practice which, while avoiding on the one hand ideological notions of the "transindividual subject," does not on the other hand dissolve the reality of revolutionary unity to a collectivity of proletarian Mallarmés.

I have considered the gains and demerits of regarding ideology as an effect of closure within signifying practices; and I want in the rest of this article to examine that thesis in relation to one of the most potent of all ideological forms—that of narrative. For narrative is certainly a paradigm case of "closure"; and I shall try to show some of the problems and misreadings which result from a superimposition of this "model" upon the structures of theoretical practice. But in asking how far narrative may nonetheless be salvaged as a valid mode, I shall also be taking issue with what I regard as a "literary ultra-leftist" view of it.

My intention is not to offer one more Marxist analysis of narrative, but to use the concept of narrative to illuminate certain aspects of Marxism itself. My project, in other words, is a primarily political one; but I hope nonetheless that this backhanded method (as it must seem from a "literary" standpoint) may produce a few insights useful to the literary critic.

At first glance, Marxism seems to take up its rank among the great narrative constructs of history. For what could be more truly fabular than the mighty world-historical plot of humanity's primordial unity, consequent alienation, revolutionary redemption, and ultimate self-recuperation in the realm of communism? Revolutionary *peripeteia* as

achieving an historical *eschaton* which is the "higher" rediscovery of a lost genesis: it is certainly possible to write historical materialism in these terms, and we all know that Marx himself more or less did so in some of his early writings. But we also know that the Marx of the early writings was only in a qualified sense a Marxist; we should not fall prey to the biographical fallacy which would consecrate with the term "Marxist" any text which appeared over the signature of the historical individual Karl Marx. To do so is merely to mistake the kind of epithet which the term "Marxist" is. Contrast, for example, the "narrative" version of Marxism I have just sketched with Marx's well-known comments on the materialist method, in the Introduction to the *Grundrisse*:

Bourgeois society is the most developed and the most complex historic organization of production. The categories which express its relations, the comprehension of its structure, thereby also allows insights into the structure and the relations of production of all the vanished social formations out of whose ruins and elements it built itself up, whose partly still unconquered remnants it carries along with it, whose mere nuances have developed explicit significance within it, etc. Human anatomy contains a key to the anatomy of the ape. The intimations of higher development among the subordinate animal species, however, can be understood only after the higher development is already known. . . .

It would therefore be unfeasible and wrong to let the economic categories follow one another in the same sequence as that in which they were historically decisive. Their sequence is determined, rather, by their relation to one another in modern bourgeois society, which is precisely the opposite of that which seems to be their natural order or which corresponds to historical development. The point is not the historic position of the economic relations in the succession of different forms of society. . . . Rather, their order within modern bourgeois society.⁹

With this passage, Marx initiates a break with any genetic-evolutionist concept of the historical materialist method, and, indeed, of its object—"history" itself. The constitutive elements of historical production—money, for example—may develop from simple to more complex forms, and the categories which "express" them shift accordingly from what Marx terms the more "abstract" to the more "concrete." But this development cannot in itself provide us with the key to an analysis of a specific mode of production. For (to continue the example), money in its simple form may occupy a *dominant* position in one historical mode of production, and, in its more complex form, a *subordinate* position in another. To put the point more succinctly: it is not "history" which gives us the structure of the present. To quote Stuart Hall's illuminating gloss on Marx's text: "What matters is not the mere appearance of (a) relation sequentially through time, but its *position* within the configuration of productive relations which makes each mode an *ensemble*. Modes of production form the discontinuous structural sets through which history articulates itself. History moves—but only as a *delayed and displaced trajectory*, through a series of social formations or ensembles. It develops by means of a series of *breaks*, engendered by the internal contradictions specific to each mode."¹⁰

In speaking of human anatomy as a key to the anatomy of the ape, Marx is suggesting a "reversible" reading of the text of history: it is only by reading the historical narrative backwards that we can render it fully intelligible. But the organic-evolutionist metaphor he selects is surely unfortunate: there is a symptomatic maladjustment here between "figure" and "discourse," a shadowy fault-line along which his text could be "deconstructed." The

⁹ *Grundrisse* (Harmondsworth, 1973), pp. 105, 107-8.

¹⁰ "Marx's Notes on Method: A Reading of the 1857 Introduction," *Cultural Studies* 5 (Birmingham University, Autumn 1974), p. 154.

thrust towards a fully “structural” reading of “history” remains partially imprisoned within an evolutionist problematic—as, indeed, do his notoriously embarrassing remarks about the “eternal charm” of ancient art in the same text. In his effort to theorize historical *continuities*, Marx finds the evolutionist problematic closest to hand, but it is clear that it will not do. For you do not escape a naively unilinear historicism merely by reversing its direction, any more than you escape a naively unilinear theory of narrative merely by insisting that Chapter 3 can only be fully understood in the light of Chapter 17. The narrative of *Nostromo* cannot be persuaded to fall beautifully into place simply by opening the book at the wrong end. Humans are a more complex development of the ape, but this genetic fact is precisely what determines their dominance over the ape in a given ecosystem, and it is precisely this conflation of “diachronic” and “synchronic” which Marx is out to problematize in the case of history. The figure is falsifying in other ways too. The structure of a dominant mode of production is significantly determined by its relations of conflict and contradiction with co-existent, “residual,” or “emergent” modes of production. But it could hardly be claimed that the structure of human social organization is significantly determined by its relations of conflict or contradiction with the “lower” species. Nor is the human anatomy thrown into conflict or self-contradiction by the persistence within it of traits inherited from its pre-human past. Nor, finally, is the model of a biological mutation or transition in the least adequate for theorizing the mutation from one historical mode of production to another. I am not claiming that Marx would reject any of these criticisms, which are in any case aimed at positions I am “reading in” to his text; I am simply trying to isolate in the crevices of his discourse the lurking presence of an organicism whose *implications* run counter to “structural” analysis. For the most unflinching statement of the kind of analysis in question, we have to turn to Nietzsche:

There is no set of maxims more important for an historian than this: that the actual causes of a thing's origins and its eventual uses, the manner of its incorporation into a system of purposes, are worlds apart; that everything that exists, no matter what its origin, is periodically reinterpreted by those in power in terms of fresh intentions; that all processes in the organic world are processes of outstripping and overcoming, and that, in turn, all outstripping and overcoming means reinterpretation, rearrangement, in the course of which the earlier meaning and purpose are necessarily either obscured or lost.¹¹

What for Nietzsche is a question of critical hermeneutics is for the mature Marx a characteristic of “history” itself.

I have said, self-evidently enough, that you do not escape a naively unilinear historicism merely by reversing its direction, and this applies also so strongly to a body of theoretical work adjacent to Marxism that I can perhaps risk a brief digression on it here. When Wordsworth writes that “the child is father to the man,” he is credited often enough with an intuitive anticipation of Freud. But Wordsworth has merely reversed the narrative: we still have fathers and children, origins and issue, openings and closures, only now the terms have been interchanged. Hierarchies of cause and effect persist, but in inverted form; a unilinear evolutionism is preserved within a reversal of direction. For Freud, however, the transition from child to adult involves first of all the disruption of this classical narrative structure. At the point of Oedipal crisis, the child rejects the emplotments of genealogy, strikes against the authority of origins, and in wishing to oust the father and possess the mother desires

¹¹ *The Genealogy of Morals* (New York, 1956), p. 102.

nothing less than to become its own father. This impossible conundrum, could it be realized, would naturally spell the death of all narrative—literally so, for since five-year-olds cannot fertilize their mothers or be fertilized by their fathers, the narrative of human genealogy would grind to a halt, and with it the production of narrative discourse. The child's wish to be self-originating promises to burst through the narrational syntagm in which it is invited under threat of castration to take up its place as one more subordinate signifier, and transforms that decorous lineage into the tangled skein of the Oedipal *text*, where narrative hierarchies of cause and effect, parent and child, self and other, past and present, are radically subverted. Edward Said has pointed to the Oedipal tangle as a sort of paradigm of modernist, anti-narrational textuality. And the same critic informs us that in Arabic societies the novel proper does not exist because of the Koran.¹² The Koran is the *original* text which strikes all subsequent ones dead at birth, condemning them to the lowly status of mere repetitions or elaborations of its primordial authority; in Harold Bloom's terminology, we might say that it has a paternal status so unspeakably strong as to castrate those subsequent texts which seek anxiously to engage it in Oedipal rivalry.¹³ The child is certainly father to the man; but it is only by a repression of Oedipal "textuality" that he becomes so. And this rupture is as remote from the organicism of a Wordsworth as Marx's mature theory of history is from the historically contemporaneous organicism of a Hegel.

In his famous opening to the *18th Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte*, Marx comments with fine sardonicism, but also with serious historical intent, on the efforts of modern revolutionaries to assume the heroic insignia of their ancient counterparts:

Hegel remarks somewhere that all facts and personages of great importance in world history occur, as it were, twice. He forgot to add: the first time as tragedy, the second as farce. . . . Thus Luther donned the mask of the apostle Paul, the Revolution of 1789 to 1814 draped itself alternately as the Roman Republic and the Roman Empire, and the Revolution of 1848 knew nothing better to do than to parody, now 1789, now the revolutionary tradition of 1793 to 1795. . . . But unheroic as bourgeois society is, it nevertheless took heroism, sacrifice, terror, civil war, and battles of peoples to bring it into being. And in the classically austere traditions of the Roman Republic its gladiators found the ideas and the art forms, the self-deceptions that they needed in order to conceal from themselves the bourgeois limitations of the content of their struggles and to keep their enthusiasm on the high plane of the great historical tragedy. . . .

The social revolution of the nineteenth century cannot draw its poetry from the past, but only from the future. . . . Earlier revolutions required recollections of past world history in order to drug themselves concerning their own content. In order to arrive at its own content the revolution of the nineteenth century must let the dead bury their dead. There the phrase went beyond the content; here the content goes beyond the phrase.

History repeats itself, but not exactly; no event quite repeats itself, precisely because it has happened once already. In attempting to recuperate the past, to affirm the consoling continuities of narrative, the present finds reflected back to itself nothing less than its own ineradicable *difference* from that "imaginary" self-image. I use the term "imaginary" here because this moment, as Marx describes it, can also be illuminatingly recast in Lacanian terms, as the irruption of symbolic heterogeneity into the sealed, mystifying circuit of the present's "mirror-relation" to the past. But one might also characterize it in more traditional

¹²See his *Beginnings* (New York, 1975).

¹³See especially *The Anxiety of Influence* (New York, 1973).

Freudian language, as an instance of that process whereby, when one drive takes over the object of another drive against which it has been "propped," a fantasmal *displacement* of the original object occurs.¹⁴ It would not be difficult, either, to read this displacement in Bloomian terms, as that "swerve" whereby the "latecoming" text deviates from its parental source. Whatever way we care to read it, it seems evident that what we have in the opening of the *18th Brumaire* are the seeds of a theory of historical "textuality" which in subverting a more entrenched theory of historical "narrative" lays bare the ideological basis of the latter. The bourgeois revolutions seek to place themselves within some privileged, primordial moment of authority, but that placing is, inevitably, a displacing, a (re)textualization of the revered "origin," which is itself only available as a "text" in the first place. It is in their pompous blindness to their own "fictionality" that the inauthenticity of their trust in simple historical linearity is revealed. The socialist revolution, by contrast, does not derive its poetry from the past: it rejects the seductive tyrannies of parental authority, and (to adopt Edward Said's terms) displaces the myth of "origins" for the practice of *beginnings*. (A "beginning" being, for Said, that thrust to transformation which knows itself as always-already situated.) The socialist revolution will take its poetry from the future, and since the future, much more palpably than the past, does not exist, this is as much as to say that it takes its poetry from *absence*. For it seems to me that the "future" of which Marx's text speaks here is not to be grasped as a utopian model to which the present must be conformed—not, in short, as a positivity—but is rather nothing less than the space into which the thrust of socialist transformation ceaselessly projects itself, the space *created* by that thrust. To posit the future as a utopia would be merely to reproduce in a different tense, so to speak, the mystifications of those who draw their utopias from the past; like them, it would be permitting the "phrase to go beyond the content" (in Marx's significantly aesthetic image), subduing the heterogeneous movement of history to the enthrallment of an imagined genesis or *eschaton*. For Marx, however, the "text" of revolutionary history is not foreclosed upon itself in this way: it lacks the symmetrical shape of narrative, dispersed as it is into textual heterogeneity ("the content goes beyond the phrase") by the absence around which it turns—the absence of an *eschaton* organically present in each of its moments. The "authority" of socialist revolution, then, is not to be located in the past, but in the intentionality of its transformative practice; its authority *is* its intentionality. It is neither derivative nor self-originating, but rather a ceaseless "beginning."

I am not, of course, suggesting that Marxism lacks an aim—merely that it does not posit an *eschaton*, which is rather different. For Marxism is certainly not a teleology: there is nothing in a given set of social relations which dictates their mutation into another. What determines that mutation, or the absence of it, is the class struggle, whose forms are of course determinate but by no means predetermined. Nor is the "goal" of historical materialism some apocalyptic self-fulfillment of the narrative of history; on the contrary, the goal of revolutionary practice is the *beginning* of history. Such a beginning is not to be misinterpreted as an *originating*—as the "creation" of an object—but as the destruction of those contradictions which inhibit the play of historical heterogeneity. In this sense, historical materialism stands to its object rather as "deconstructive" criticism stands to its text. Its task is to refuse the phenomenal coherence of that text's narrative presence in order to expose the generative mechanisms which produce its repressed, self-contradictory

¹⁴See Jean Laplanche, *Life and Death in Psychoanalysis*, translated by Jeffrey Mehlerman (Baltimore, 1976), Chapter 1, *passim*.

heterogeneity. This, precisely, is what Marx's *Capital* undertakes; it is of crucial significance that the founding document of Marxism, unlike that of Christianity, is *not a narrative*.

We can pursue this analogy between literary texts and Marxism a little further. The relation between Marxism and its object contains an irony which is also evident in the relation between a text and history. All literary texts have beginnings and ends, and are thus inevitably modeled in part on a narrative structure which they may nonetheless refuse. But in what sense history itself has a beginning and an end is problematic. Empirically speaking, of course, history certainly had a beginning and will no doubt have an end; but we cannot speak of the moment of origin of history, for to *speak* of it means that we are already subsequent to it—always already in the midst of significations. We cannot think ourselves back beyond language, for we need language in order to do so in the first place. The origin of history can never be a *presence*; it is, rather, a moment continually displaced and absented by that play of textualization which signifies that we are always already posterior to it. An origin is nothing to speak of. Similarly, we cannot speak of the end of history because there is no end as long as we can still speak of it. "The worst is not, So long as we can say 'This is the worst'": Edgar's comment in *King Lear* might profitably be studied in relation to the work of Jacques Derrida. The "end" is perpetually deferred by the discourse which at once posits and negates it. Now there is a sense in which this might be said of literary discourse too. What is the "beginning" of *The Rainbow*? It might be an answer to say: "Hardy's *Jude the Obscure*." But in a straightforward sense *The Rainbow* does have a beginning and an end, and this indeed is one of the aesthetic problems with which it must grapple. For if the text itself has an obvious start and finish, the evolving genealogies with which it deals do not; its relation to its "material" is consequently ironic, as indeed is the relation of every literary text to its "object." The "modernist" text is simply the one which has incorporated this irony as the very structuration of its discourse—which, like *Tristram Shandy* or *Finnegans Wake*, deconstructs narrative linearity into a textual heterogeneity forever impossible as long as books exist.

It is important to distinguish this argument from the tedious liberal cliché that fiction "organizes the chaos of reality." "Life is chaotic; art is orderly," Lord David Cecil once remarked, but it is difficult to catch glimpses of cosmic chaos in the progression from a tutorial in the morning, lunch in the Senior Common Room, and a visit to Hatfield House in the afternoon. Well, perhaps it is *experience* which seems chaotic, as it did to Virginia Woolf, but it is unlikely that it seemed particularly so to the proletariat who produced the wealth which enabled her to meditate on the random contingencies of living. Historical "textuality" is always a *determinate* plurality of signifiers, not a disorganized sprawl of sense. The task of Marxism, as I have said, is to identify and transform the generative mechanisms of that determinate plurality, but the "content" that will thereby be produced will, to revert to Marx's phrase, "go beyond the phrase." The aim of socialist revolution is to abolish commodity production by the institution of workers' self-government, but the consequent overriding of "quantity" by "quality," of the measured homogeneity of exchange values by the "measureless" heterogeneity of use values, cannot be "read off" from the social forms which generate it. Marxism, as an inevitably "limited text," thus stands in ironic relation to the historical "text" it exists to bring into being, and whose emergence will signal its own demise. One might find a kind of parallel to this process in the two, mutually ironizing texts which inhabit the single literary text we know as *Ulysses*. One of these texts—the structural, "metaphorical" or mythological text which tells of the relations, substitutions and condensations between Stephen, Bloom, and Molly—concerns the generative mechanisms, the

conditions of possibility, which are necessary if Stephen is to become an artist and (one might surmise) the text of *Ulysses* is therefore to be written. The other text—the “realist” or metonymic one—is precisely the movement of symbolic heterogeneity produced by these mechanisms, the “content” which comically surpasses the “form.”

If, for Jacques Derrida, we are always already posterior to the luminous presence of the “real,” if there is something always given in advance, the same is true in a different sense for Marxism. What is always already anterior for Marxism is “material conditions”; where “consciousness” is, there material conditions have been. Fredric Jameson has noted this parallel: “In this context, [Derrida’s] ‘trace’ thus becomes a striking, symbolic way of conveying Marx’s ever-scandalous discovery that ‘it is not the consciousness of men that determines their existence, but on the contrary their social existence determines their consciousness.’”¹⁵ We cannot lift ourselves up by our bootstraps back behind “material conditions” to an “origin,” for all we shall find will be yet more anterior conditions; we cannot project ourselves back beyond the materiality of discourse to the ghostly thought in which it originated, for that thought will be always already inscribed in the material of a signification. And this is clearly one sense in which “history,” for Marxism, is not a narrative: for what kind of narrative is it which has always already begun, which has an infinitely deferred end, and which in consequence can hardly be spoken of as having a middle?

But there is another, equally important sense in which “history” for Marxism figures as “text” rather than “narrative.” In *Reading Capital*, Althusser speaks in a famous passage of that idealist and historicist notion of history for which historical time is “continuous and homogeneous and contemporaneous with itself”¹⁶—that unilinear exfoliation in which, since each moment teems with the burden of the whole, diachrony is no more than a kind of phenomenal appearance of a secret synchrony. To this conception Althusser counterposes a radically “deconstructed” concept of the historical:

As a first approximation, we can argue from the specific structure of the Marxist whole that it is no longer possible to think the process of the development of the different levels of the whole *in the same historical time*. Each of these different “levels” does not have the same type of historical existence. On the contrary, we have to assign to each level a *peculiar time*, relatively autonomous, and hence relatively independent, even in its dependence, of the “times” of the other levels. We can and must say: for each mode of production there is a peculiar time and history, punctuated in a specific way by the development of the productive forces; the relations of production have their peculiar time and history, punctuated in a specific way; the political superstructure has its own history...; philosophy has its own time and history...¹⁷

And, of course, as Althusser goes on to say, aesthetic production too. The first task of a Marxist aesthete is not to provide “materialist” readings within the coherent narrative of literary history, but to deconstruct that ideological coherence and construct in its place a concept of the “time of literary production.” That “time”—which will allow us to identify the groupings and dispersals of “literary” discursive practices within a discursive formation itself articulated upon other formations—will have little in common with the “Dickens to Hardy” chronology of orthodox literary history.

Althusser’s concept of differential histories has a suggestive relation to the modernist notion of “textuality.” For what constitutes a *text* is, precisely, differentiation, the determinate

¹⁵ *The Prison-House of Language* (Princeton, 1972), p. 184.

¹⁶ *Reading Capital* (London, 1970), p. 98.

¹⁷ *Ibid.*, p. 99.

splay and dispersal of the codes which compose its "tissue," which can never be reduced to some governing metastructure or informing essence. As such, it subverts the consolations of classical narrative, the ideological basis of which are clearly enough revealed in this sentence from Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending*:

Peripeteia, which has been called the equivalent, in narrative, of irony in rhetoric, is present in every story of the least structural sophistication. Now peripeteia depends on our confidence of the end; it is a disconfirmation followed by a consonance; the interest of having our expectations falsified is obviously related to our wish to reach the discovery or recognition by an unexpected and instructive route.¹⁸

Reverse those formulations, speak of a consonance followed by a disconfirmation, recognition followed by falsification, and you have something like the formula for Brecht's epi(sodi)c theatre. Not that narrative is to be written off as a ruling-class conspiracy, or for that matter that all narratives end on a note of consonance. But whether they end well or badly, the fact is that they end; and not only that they *end*, but that *they* end—that the end, whether tragic or felicitous, arbitrary or predetermined, "closed" or "open," is the end of *this* piece of discourse, and as such is part of its shape. However "arbitrary" or "open" the ending may be, it still rounds off the text "syntactically," even if it does not do so "semantically"; and ideology is carried as much in syntax as in semantics. If George Eliot had decided in a fit of wild abandon to kill off all the characters of *Middlemarch* in the final paragraph, she would certainly have radically undermined Victorian ideological expectations and the novel would never have been published, but she would not have undermined them as effectively as she would have done if she had finished the novel in mid-sentence.

Narrative, far from constituting some ruling-class conspiracy, is a valid and ineradicable mode of all human experience. More precisely, it is the very form of the ideological; and since the ideological will not disappear with the dismantling of class-society, neither will narrative. As Jameson has put it, "the ideological representation must . . . be seen as that indispensable mapping fantasy or narrative by which the individual subject invents a 'lived' relationship with collective systems."¹⁹ We cannot think, act, or desire except in narrative; it is by narrative that the subject constructs that "sutured" chain of signifiers which grants its true condition of division sufficient "imaginary" coherence to enable it to act. The insertion of the subject into an ideological formation is simultaneously its access to a repertoire of narrative conventions and devices which provide it with a stable self-identity through time. We know that the "truth" of the subject has no such stable self-identity; the unconscious knows no narrative. But this is not to say that narrative is merely "illusory," any more than we should chide the working-class movement for nurturing its mighty narrative dreams of universal brotherhood overcoming the evils of capitalism. Such *motifs* are the inevitable, indispensable ideological inflections by which the theory of historical materialism "lives itself out" in the practice of class struggle. And just as the individual subject is permitted, by its insertion in an ideological formation, to construct for itself a coherent narrative history, so a revolutionary or potentially revolutionary class forges, across the structural discontinuities of social formations known to Marxism, the ideological "fiction" of a coherent and continuous struggle.

We need to beware, then, of treating narrative rather as some of the most devoted

¹⁸*The Sense of an Ending* (London, 1966), p. 18.

¹⁹"Imaginary and Symbolic in Lacan," *Yale French Studies*, 55/56 (1978), p. 394.

neophytes of Jacques Lacan treat the “imaginary,” or as Louis Althusser sometimes behaves towards the notion of “everyday life”—grudgingly acknowledging its centrality and indispensability while suggesting by one’s tone that one would really after all rather be shut out of it. The narrative model may well constitute an ideological deformation of *theory*; but it is the merest formalism to argue that, because narrative necessarily involves closure, it is inherently regressive and reactionary. The ideological effect indeed consists in the arresting of a chain of polyvocal signification in such a way as to fix, stabilize, and privilege certain signifiers which then, becoming as they do the modes in which the subject’s “lived” relation to the “real” is articulated, contribute to the securing of the conditions of existence of certain dominant social relations. But nothing secures that securing: those privileged signifiers thus become the space of a *struggle*, so that we are able cursorily to define ideology as “the class-struggle at the level of signifying practices.” The transformation of those signifiers may well take the form of a refusal of closure itself, an unleashing of plurality, transgression, and contradiction which dissolves “narrative” into “text”; but its other moment, necessary if we are to avoid a formalistic, essentialist valorizing of “plurality” and “heterogeneity” *in themselves*, and a consequent reversion to some debased *Lebensphilosophie*, is the fight for the installment of alternative, socialist significations, and thus for an alternative, if always provisional, kind of closure.

I have advisedly used the term “fiction” of socialist ideology, as opposed to the Sorelian notion of “myth.” For Sorel, the proletariat, inert, chronically retarded creatures that they were, could only be stimulated into revolutionary practice under the catalytic influence of a “myth”—a myth whose falsity was plain enough to the intellectual vanguard set above them. Kermode, however (to allude to him once again, this time more approvingly), enforces a distinction between “myth” and “fiction”: fictions are in some sense conscious of their fictionality, myths, as “degenerate fictions,” are not. Socialist ideology seems to me in this sense “fictional” because it knows itself not to be “theory.” To put the matter another way, it knows itself not to be *propositional*, and in that sense is quite irrelevant to questions of truth and falsity, as the myth of the infallibility of the pope is not. In this, once again, there is an analogy with the modernist text. All literary texts are parodies of speech-acts—“virtual” or “pseudo” speech-acts—but the modernist text knows itself to be such, raising the parody to the second power.

Kermode speaks of the contrast between history as “*chronos*” and history as “*kairos*”—between the mere passing of time, and that dramatic moment in which time is suddenly “seasonal,” “charged with a meaning derived from its relation to the end.”²⁰ And it is not difficult to see how much classical narrative combines the two: one thing happens, and then another, and then something else which promises to transform everything. This is also a way of reading history—say, the history of the capitalist mode of production. For a while things slide along smoothly, and then there occurs a sudden crisis or disruption or revolution. The normal condition is one of continuity, but a continuity punctuated by occasional ruptures. It is indeed the case that the nature of the reproduction of the social relations of production under capitalism lends itself to this ideological miscognition, but it is a miscognition for all that. For what it fails to see is that every such reproduction of the social relations, every valorization of capital, is the result of a *struggle*—of a class struggle conducted day by day and hour by hour at the very point of (re)production. Capitalism is a system of ceaseless transformations, within which *peripeteia* is not punctual but persistent. It is thus not a

²⁰*Op. cit.*, p. 47.

system which can be encompassed by the logic of classical narrative or structural analysis, but only by a method attuned to a perpetual process of "textual" transformations, whether this is called "semanalysis," or more traditionally, "dialectics."

I want to end with a rather lengthy quotation from Michel Foucault which sums up much of what I have said:

Continuous history is the indispensable correlative of the founding function of the subject: the guarantee that everything that has eluded him may be restored to him; the certainty that time will disperse nothing without restoring it in a reconstituted unity; the promise that one day the subject—in the form of historical consciousness—will once again be able to appropriate, to bring back under his sway, all those things that are kept at a distance by difference, and find in them what might be called his abode. . .

But to seek in this great accumulation of the already-said the text that resembles "in advance" a later text, to ransack history in order to rediscover the play of anticipations or echoes, to go right back to the first seeds or to go forward to the last traces, to reveal in a work its fidelity to tradition or its irreducible uniqueness, to raise or lower its stock of originality, to say that the Port-Royal grammarians invented nothing, or to discover that Cuvier had more predecessors than one thought, these are harmless enough amusements for historians who refuse to grow up.²¹

²¹ *The Archaeology of Knowledge* (London, 1972), pp. 12, 144.

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[Footnotes]

¹⁹ **Imaginary and Symbolic in Lacan: Marxism, Psychoanalytic Criticism, and the Problem of the Subject**

Fredric Jameson

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